SUNDAY 18 OCTOBER 2026

Twenty Ninth Sunday Ordinary Time

M I S S I O N M O N T H

NEWSLETTER FOR THE PARISHES OF THE WEST TYRONE PASTORAL AREA:

Aghyaran • Ardstraw West & Castlederg • Drumquin

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SCHEDULE FOR THIS WEEK:

DAY	AGHYARAN	ARDSTRAW WEST & CASTLEDERG	DRUMQUIN
Monday 19 Oct		**Mass, Castlederg: 7.30pm**	**Mass, 10.00am** **Rosary, 8.00pm**
Tuesday 20 Oct	**Mass, 10.00am**	**Rosary, Castlederg: 2.00pm**	**Rosary, 10.00am**
Wednesday 21 Oct	**Liturgy of Word with Holy Communion: 10.00am**	**Castlederg: Liturgy of the Word, with Holy Communion: 10.00am** **Dregish: Rosary, 11.00am**	**Mass, 10.00am**
Thursday 22 Oct	**Mass, 10.00am, followed by Adoration until 12.00noon**		
Friday 23 Oct		**Mass, Castlederg: 10.00am, followed by Adoration until 12.00noon**	**Mass, 7.30pm**
Saturday 24 Oct	**Vigil Mass, 7.30pm**	**Vigil Mass, Castlederg, 6.15pm**	**Vigil Mass: 5.00pm**
Sunday 25 Oct	*Mass on 1st and 3rd Sunday*	**Mass: Dregish, 9.30am** **Castlederg, 11.00am** **Drumnabey,12.30pm**	*Mass on 1st and 3rd Sunday*

THANK YOU for your generosity in last week's collection:
AGHYARAN: £711 & €14; Church Restoration Fund: £597 & €27.
ARDSTRAW WEST & CASTLEDERG: £2,260 & €87, made up of:
Castlederg £1,318 & €59, **Drumnabey** £447 & €22, **Dregish** £495 & £6. **DRUMQUIN:** £427.

PASTORAL VISITATION of the housebound will take place this week as follows**:**
Monday 19 October - Crockett Park, Young Crescent and Drumnabey - commencing at 11.00am - Fr Paul.

SVP MEETING in the Parochial House, Drumquin, this Wednesday, 21 October, at 7.30pm.

ARDSTRAW WEST AND CASTLEDERG Parish Draw: Draw will take place next Sunday, 25 October, in Dregish.

Today is Mission Sunday. The Propagation of the Faith collection will be taken up as a second collection at our Masses this weekend. The proceeds of this collection are channelled through Missio Ireland, the official support organisation for the overseas mission of the Church.
Today we remember in a special way all those from our parishes whose vocation has led them to serve as missionaries in foreign lands – priests, religious and lay-people, past and present. Remembering Pope Leo's theme for Mission Sunday – One in Christ, united in mission - we give thanks for their vocation and dedication in bringing the Gospel to others. May God continue to bless them in their mission.

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We pray for the happy repose of the souls of Michael (Mickey) McCallion, late of Castlefin Road, Castlederg, whose Funeral Mass took place in Drumnabey on Wednesday, and Mary Ann (Molly) Carlin, late of Kilcroagh Road, whose Funeral Mass took place in Castlederg on Saturday. We offer our sympathy and our prayerful support to their families and to all who mourn their deaths. May they rest in peace.

CASTLEDERG SURGERY - Flu/Covid Clinics - Tue 20 - Tue 27 October – 2.00pm – 5.00pm. Text messages have been sent for patients to book their appointment or by letter those without a mobile. It is important that you make contact with the surgery on 028 816 71211, Option 3, to book an appointment. If these dates do not suit, you can book an appointment for Newtownstewart Surgery – Wed 21 October, 2.00pm - 5.30pm or Thurs 29 October, 2.00pm to 5.00pm.

IVY'S DANCE – CASTLEDERG COMMITTEE OF CANCER RESEARCH UK: Saturday 31 October, Scraghey Community Centre. Dancing from 9.30pm. Music by Charlie and Claire. Adm £8. Raffle on the night. Light refreshments will be served.

AUTUMN SALE – CASTLEDERG COMMITTEE OF CANCER RESEARCH UK: Saturday 19 – Friday 23 October, 11.00am – 8.00pm, in the Aghyaran Centre. All items of furniture, clothing and bric-a-brac will be gratefully accepted.

DANCE in Garvagh Hall this Friday, 23 October - Music by The Lakelanders - Dancing 9.00 – 12.00midnight. Refreshments served.

A Heartfelt Thank You

Dear friends,

As I prepare to take up my new appointment as Parish Priest of Drumragh (Omagh) on 30th October, I wish to record my deep gratitude to you all for your kindness, support and generosity, both in the life of the parishes and to me personally, for the last seven years. Throughout my seven years of ministry in Aghyaran and Ardstraw West & Castlederg, and three years in Drumquin, I have been supported by wonderful teams of people who have walked with me and, on so many occasions, somehow made the impossible possible! I feel very blessed to have been part of the faith story of the people of the three parishes and, in thanking you for the very significant role you have played in inspiring an encouraging me in my own faith journey, I very much hope that, in some small way, my ministry among you has helped and encouraged you on your own journey of faith.

I could never have managed without the help I have had in the Parochial House, the Office, our churches, our halls, graveyards and our schools. To our parish secretary, newsletter editor, sacristans, caretakers, school staff and volunteers: thank you. You kept everything going, often with little recognition or outward expressions of gratitude. And behind all of our liturgies there lies an 'army' of people – readers, eucharistic ministers, altar servers, musicians/choirs, collectors, counters, cleaners, groundsmen, caretakers – people who just show up faithfully and willingly, week in and week out. Special thanks too to those who have given of their gifts, knowledge and time on parish committees including the various fundraising groups, parish tea group, children's liturgy and, more recently, on our Leadership Teams. I am indebted also to the staff and children of our schools for their warm welcome at all times and their co-operation and willingness to share in the life of our churches and parishes.

I have been privileged to accompany many families and individuals on milestone occasions in their lives over the last seven years. It is always wonderful to share with families in the happy, joyful occasions – the baptisms, weddings, Golden Weddings, First Communions, Confirmations and other achievements. Part of priestly ministry of course is journeying with families in their darkest hours – families facing illness, death and the loss of loved ones, sometimes in the most heartbreaking circumstances. It has been a privilege for me to have walked with many families in sad, difficulty and challenging times in their lives. Again, I have found the faith and courage shown by so many families at such times to be deeply humbling, and a source of strength and reassurance to me in my own faith.

An important part of any priest's ministry is visiting and bringing the Eucharist to those who are housebound or unable to come to church. Visitation of the housebound in our parishes has been a very privileged part of my ministry; so too has visitation of our Nursing Homes.

We came through Covid together, and we've shared seven Christmases and Easters. I won't forget any of this! In recent years it has also been a joy to have Fr Thomas minister alongside me. His generosity and helpfulness have been a great blessing. Thank you, Fr Thomas, for all your support. My thanks too to Fr Gilmore for his wise counsel, and to Fr Peter McCawille for the generous help he continues to give to us all. I leave with a heavy heart, but also with memories of friendship and neighbourliness that, for me, make the Gospel come alive.

Last but not least, I want to say a word of welcome to my successor, Fr Chris. There are a good many projects underway or just about to begin, but Fr Chris is talented, capable and hardworking, and I have no worries on that score. With your help and encouragement, and with his leadership, I know the people of these three parishes will grow stronger in faith and keep the light of the Gospel burning brightly, a beacon of hope in a fragile world. I hope Fr Chris will be as happy here as I have been, and I ask God's blessing on all that you do together.
Please keep me in your thoughts and prayers. I'll always keep the people of this pastoral area in mine, asking that God will reward you for all your goodness and kindness.

With love and gratitude,

Fr Paul